

I'm an African international student from Tunisia, currently seeking asylum in the United States. I hold an F1 visa.

To be able to remain enrolled, Armand Link, an undergraduate Computer Science major in GS, generously co-signed a private educational loan for me so that I could keep my student visa and avoid deportation. He recognized the suffering I have experienced, as a fellow gay man, the persecution I endured in Tunisia where homosexuality is illegal. He co-signed my loan so that I could continue my education and avoid deportation. There is a Columbia article in which he shares his experience:

<https://www.gs.columbia.edu/news/their-own-words-river-divided-my-childhood-and-shaped-my-future>

In addition, to afford Columbia thus far, I have relied on fundraising. The 116th Initiative, an organization dedicated to helping Columbia students navigate financial hardship, organized a campaign on my behalf. Through the generosity of many members of the Columbia community, we raised approximately \$17,000. This was extremely challenging, and it required the support of many Columbia students to help me keep my visa and avoid deportation. The campaign was featured on their official Instagram: https://www.instagram.com/p/C_Q37ESJ7r0/?hl=en&img_index=1 and https://www.instagram.com/p/C_lTepJpi7X/?hl=en&img_index=1

\$17,000 was spent on Columbia summer housing and Fall 2025 tuition. I currently have an outstanding balance and a hold on my account. As a low-income African, Muslim immigrant, asylum seeker, and LGBTQ Columbia student, I'm writing to kindly ask for Columbia's support, I sincerely hope to be able to complete my education and graduate in 2026.

At the moment, I'm trying to navigate any possible way to cover my educational costs, I'm asking some of my friends to apply for credit cards in the hope that, if they are approved, they might be able to assist me with the current hold on my account. However, my friends are also low income and generally have low credit scores, so this option is uncertain. Additionally, my friends and I are currently reaching out to many organizations and friends to explore any funding opportunities. Since I'm an international student, funding opportunities are very limited. We are also considering trying to find someone else who could help co-sign for a second educational loan, or perhaps someone who would be willing to take a personal loan and use it to help me pay for my education.

I currently have a campus job/internship at CCIT (\$20/hr) and have been working there for about three weeks. Due to funding cuts, I'm capped at about 12 hours per week maximum. I also have monthly loan payments of \$1,000, which I must make on my previous private educational loan. Because the interest rate is approximately 18%, all of my campus job income goes

toward this monthly payment, leaving me with no realistic way to put those earnings toward my tuition balance.

Support from Columbia at this time would be truly crucial in allowing me to remain enrolled, continue my education, avoid deportation, and complete my degree. Thank you in advance for your kind consideration.